End the violence in the Middle East Now and for Good

We, the undersigned former staff members of the United Nations system, call on the UN member states and the UN Secretary-General to take every possible action to put an immediate and permanent end to the war in Gaza and Lebanon.

Despite repeated calls for a cease fire and access to humanitarian assistance from numerous quarters, the horrific violence continues. The loss of life, the deprivation and destruction are ever-mounting, with the heaviest toll falling on the civilian population of Gaza, where Israel's actions have been characterized by the International Court of Justice as of possible genocidal intent. With the war now extending into Lebanon, and hostilities also involving the rest of the Occupied Palestinian Territory (i.e. the West Bank and East Jerusalem), Syria, Iran, Iraq and Yemen, the world is faced with violence engulfing the entire Middle East region and possibly beyond.

Having ourselves served with the UN around the world, we are appalled by Israel's military attacks against UNRWA, UNIFIL and other United Nations agencies engaged in humanitarian assistance or peacekeeping. These attacks have already taken the lives of over 200 of our colleagues. We also condemn the continuous verbal and political attacks by the Israeli government against the United Nations, including the Secretary-General, for doing their duty as mandated by the UN Charter.

It is time for the UN Security Council and General Assembly to exercise the greatest possible pressure on the most powerful and lethal of the parties to these conflicts – the government of Israel -- to stop its aggression toward Palestinian and Lebanese civilians.

This means, among other actions, suspending the shipment of arms to Israel, and if necessary, applying economic sanctions, as recently suggested by several governments.

The same course needs to be pursued with Hamas, Hezbollah and their supporters, particularly the government of Iran. We take this opportunity to reiterate our condemnation of the brutal terrorist attack perpetrated by Hamas on October 7, 2023, including the kidnapping of civilians.

All actors in this conflict must renounce acts of violence and terror against civilians regardless of whether or not they are being specifically targeted.

The most urgent goals for the world today is to shield the people of Gaza and Lebanon from further violence and to ensure that humanitarian assistance reaches them as soon as possible.

This should be the first step toward negotiating a permanent solution to the conflict that recognizes and embraces the right of all peoples in the region to live in peace, safety, dignity and prosperity.

Let us not allow recognition of the right of Israel to defend itself to justify what is being done to the people of Gaza and Lebanon. The killing of tens of thousands of civilians and rendering hundreds of thousands of people homeless and on the brink of famine is not self-defense. It is a crime against humanity and a clear violation of International Law.

Faced with such a crime, the only acceptable path for humanity is to take every possible action to stop the carnage now or to resign ourselves to becoming accomplices.

The choice is clear. Let us act ***now***.